CHAPTER 13

THE MATCH THAT MATTERS

Shakama Private Game Lodge is located at the foot of the southern Waterberg Mountains, a little more than an hour's drive north of Pretoria; it's one of those places that make our country feel special.

'Well, if we're not going to play golf, what are we going to do?' asked Jan, my older brother, one day in May 2007.

'We could go have lunch at Shakama,' my mother replied.

'What happens there?' I asked.

'It's a game lodge, and I'm helping to sell the plots,' said my mother, who worked as an estate agent.

We agreed and, just as we were leaving after a great lunch, my mother introduced us to the owner, John Swart. He said he wanted us to meet his wife and children, and went to call them.

'This is my daughter Danielle.'

It was the eyes, the beautiful eyes. The long brown hair was striking, but it was the eyes that instantly caught my attention. I said hello, she said hello and, amid the family greetings, that was that.

Back at our car, I asked my mother whether she could get a mobile number for the daughter with the beautiful eyes. A few days later, I sent Danielle a text, asking whether she and some of her friends might want to come out with me and a few of my friends one evening in Pretoria. There would be safety in a group. She replied, and accepted,